

Unjust Religion as Fiction

Montaque Reynolds

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1 Working Papers 2026 – Status Dashboard

Current status as of `r format(Sys.Date(), '%B %Y')`

1.1 Active Papers

Manticore

- ☐ Literature Review
- ☐ Primary texts read & noted
- ☐ Brainstorm Core Argument
- ☐ Draft paper outline with main sections
- ☐ Write first draft
- ☐ Share draft with trusted colleagues
- ☐ Identify possible objections
- ☐ Research Relevant Conferences
- ☐ Research target journals for submission
- ☐ Objections section started
- ☐ Responses to objections
- ☐ Submit to journal X by end of Q2

The Aesthetic Problem of Evil

- ☐ Literature Review
- ☐ Primary texts read & noted
- ☐ Brainstorm Core Argument
- ☐ Draft paper outline with main sections
- ☐ Write first draft
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1.1.1 Morality as Privilege

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- ☐ Submit to journal X by end of Q2

1.1.2 God as the Best Possible Epistemic Ground of Human Dignity

- ☐ Literature Review
 - ☐ Imago Dei as Human Identity by Ryan Peterson
- ☐ Primary texts read & noted
- ☐ Brainstorm Core Argument
- ☐ Draft paper outline with main sections
- ☐ Write first draft
- ☐ Share draft with trusted colleagues
- ☐ Identify possible objections
- ☐ Research Relevant Conferences
- ☐ Research target journals for submission
- ☐ Objections section started
- ☐ Responses to objections
- ☐ Submit to journal X by end of Q2

1.2 Next Up

- [Aesthetics of Evil](#)

Part I

Active Papers

2 Aesthetics of Evil

Montaque Reynolds (Stetson University)

2.1 Abstract

In medieval bestiaries, there are two classes of evil represented by beasts; those which deceive and those which generate fear and death. Among the first class of beasts, those which are notable for their abilities to deceive, there are three kinds of deception: these are noted by the camouflages of the chameleon, accurate imitations of the manticore, and the “seductive skills of sirens”.

- **Deceivers:** Camouflage, imitation, seduction
 - Chameleon: camouflage
 - Manticore: accurate imitations
 - Sirens: seductive skills
- **Fear and Death Generators**

While we might think this to be a medieval taxonomy of epistemic harms only, the kinds of epistemic harms the medievalists worried about are not far off from contemporary epistemic harms and risks; misinformation, false and inauthentic narratives, and bullsh*t. This article looks at those beasts which represent epistemic harms and attempts to develop an account of inauthentic narrative as a moral harm.

2.2 Pinero: Beasts as Symbols of Evil

The Manticore is a fictionalized beast that was born in Persian art and literature sometime around Persia’s cultural zenith. It at once symbolizes evil, death and hell, but in medieval religious art, it came to symbolize the power of Christ over death and hell.

It is an imagined beast that has been found in literature as early as the 5th and 4th century BC. In his Photius, the Greek historian working for the Persian court describes the Manticore

as a beast with red skin, as large as a lion, possessing three rows of teeth, a human-like face and the tail of a scorpion. Later writers would quote Ctesias' description of the Manticore adding emphasis on its dietary habits, including that it ate men. Though it is likely that many of these descriptions were of predatory animals passed by word of mouth until they reached the Persian king's court, what is even more important is the way in which these descriptions begin to stand in for imageries of evil in the Medieval literature and specifically the kinds of evil they begin to represent.

On some accounts, the manticore is a union between a hyena and Ethiopian lioness. It imitates the voices of men and possesses a fixed and immovable gaze. In addition, it does not possess gums in either of its jaws, and rather than having multiple teeth, it has one large one that curves around its jaw bone.

Ctesias' description includes that the Manticore had a triple row of teeth which fit into each other like a comb, the face and ears of a human, blood colored eyes, the body of a lion and a stinging tail similar to a scorpion. While Pliny the elder argued that it imitated the voices of men, Ctesias tells us that its voice resembles a union of a flute and trumpet, that it is exceedingly swift, and has an appetite for human flesh [p. 280].

Aristotle questions Ctesias' account, but nevertheless preserves it in his own writings. He also reproduces Ctesias' account, that the Manticore possesses a double rather than triple row of teeth, has similar feet as a lion and is similar in size to a lion. What is perhaps important are the anthropomorphic descriptions including those of the ears and face of a human, and that it has non-anthropomorphic ones such as grey eyes and red body and possesses a tail like that of a scorpion. [p. 30-31; also see Aristotle, *History of Animals* 8.28, 605b22-606a10]

Owing to the fantastical nature of these accounts, it is highly probable that they are either misguided representations of some more familiar animal, or motivated by purposes other than truth. In the classical era, it is most likely the case that the Manticore is a confused representation of some other more familiar animal, while in the medieval period, the motivation for the representation lies outside of truth.

On this second point, in the 57th question of the 1st of the second part of the *Summa Theologica*, Thomas Aquinas defends the view of art as a form of right reason. There is a distinction here between the right reason for making objects, and the right reason for doing good actions. We should first focus on a central point here, what is important to both of these activities, namely the right use of one's cognitive faculties. Therefore, the difference here lies in the produced object, whether an action or thing.

2.2.1 Art as an Orthodox End

We might think that medieval art has no place in a discussion about epistemic injustice, but I argue that the depiction of the fictional beast called the manticore, as a personification of deception lends credibility to this claim. According to the modern function of art summed

up by Gilmore (2020), art's function is oriented to ends such as pleasure, entertainment, and absorption [132]. Conversely, the medieval function of art is directed at more orthodox ends intending to motivate desirable behaviors and behavioral responses. According to views centering on epistemic injustice, because of a misappropriated power imbalance, a person holds false beliefs about themselves. These beliefs stem from unjust environments where the individual lacks access to resources that would lead to accurate self-understanding and moral beliefs. Such beliefs are rooted in irrational actions performed by that individual.

It does this by contrasting the concept of hermeneutic justice as popularized by Miranda Fricker (2007) but developed by earlier feminists. We might think that medieval art has no place in a discussion about epistemic injustice, but I argue that the depiction of the fictional beast called the manticore, as a personification of deception lends credibility to this claim. According to the modern function of art, art's function is oriented to ends such as pleasure, entertainment, and absorption (Gilmore 2020, 132). Conversely, the medieval function of art is directed at more orthodox ends, ones intending to motivate behaviors and behavioral responses. As an artistic object, the Manticore is a fictionalized beast that was born in Persian art and literature sometime around its cultural zenith. It at once symbolizes evil, death and hell, but in medieval religious art, it came to symbolize the power of Christ over death and hell.

3 Pinero

Piñero Moral (2021) argues that this is because art's purpose in the middle ages is to represent reality. It is one thing to accurately and factually represent a tree, however, Pinero is talking about more complex reality, especially moral reality. One example of medieval representations of moral reality include the Persian Manticore. The manticore as depicted in medieval art is said to represent evil.

There are several ways in which some art objects may represent more complex realities. One may think that the purpose of a painting is to reflect the experiences one had during a war, or peace time event. Such a painting may express the given facts of the case, for instance an artist could paint the signing of the Magna Carta. If the painting were painted by an artist who was alive to witness the signing of the Magna Carta, then the artist would merely be representing contemporary reality. If the artist were not alive at the time, then we could argue that the artist is representing historical reality. The artist is relying on trusted and well known sources would be different from the artist imagining an event in which not many direct sources exist. But an artist can represent a projection of reality as well when the reality they want to convey is obscure, not well known, highly contested or hypothetical.

According to this definition of medieval art, art implies metaphysical aspirations and normative elements (Also see De Bruyne 1959). Its commitment to reality is undeniable, yet the reality which it attempts to represent is so complex and vast that the limits between what is and what is not, between what we believe and what we know, between what we are and what we wish to be, are often blurred (cron41?).

Here, the artist can represent facts as they believe them to be, or as they wish them to be. It is this latter motivation that Pinero suggests motivated medieval artwork representing the manticore. There is a difference here then between modern and medieval artistic function. This in itself is uninteresting. However, what may be more interesting to the reader, is the further claim that this difference can be applied in response to the contemporary account of epistemic injustice.

Susan Pepper-Gates in a forth-coming paper writes a very engaging and important paper article applying Miranda Fricker (2007)'s analysis of epistemic injustice to contemporary Western Religion WR, and the Philosophy of Religion, PoWR. She argues that the philosophy of religion should cultivate epistemic-ethical virtues in order to recognize and include philosophers from minority voices. Doing so helps WR and PoWR understand and recognize the ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings.

I think that the initial conclusion is a strong one. Namely the ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings is important for concepts that we associate with who we are. However, I think that the most important conclusion here is a premise conclusion statement. Rather than WR and PoWR cultivating epistemic virtues, WR and PoWR should focus on the cultivation of epistemic virtues, meaning that they should focus on how epistemic virtue is created. This will give the project of WR and PoWR two convergent aims.

1. First, it would be to draw attention to the ways in which power *can* shape our lives as embodied social beings.
2. Cultivating virtue in this context then, means that WR and PoWR ought be formative, cultivating virtue in their audiences.
3. However, possessing virtue in this sense, makes it less likely that power will shape the lives of WR and PoWR's audiences.

3.1 Some Questions

A central question here is one of difference in kinds of harm. Specifically what kind of harm is being done. Additionally, is the kind of harm that we care about adjudicated solely in virtue of racial, or ethnic distinctiveness?

3.2 Peppers-Gates Analysis of Fricker

Peppers-Gates first points out that Western Religion, WR, and The Philosophy of Western Religion, PoWR, have historically ignored work by intersectional feminist philosophers and philosophers of race who challenge the traditional approach. However, how is this done? First, traditional epistemology, TE, focuses on abstract universal knowledge while the philosophy of religion has traditionally grounded itself in TE by focusing on rational belief.

In order for the philosophy of religion to cultivate epistemic-ethical virtues, it should recognize and include philosophers from minority voices. Peppers-Gates argument takes the following form:

1. Traditional epistemology focuses on abstract universal knowledge.
2. Philosophy of religion grounds itself in traditional epistemology and focuses on rational belief.
3. Therefore WR and PoWR embrace narrow methodologies that exclude others and contributes to the marginalization of minority voices.
4. Given its focus on abstract universal knowledge and its marginalization of minority voices, WR and PoWR ignore work by intersectional feminist philosophers and philosophers of race who challenge the traditional approach and argue that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings.

5. As such, WR and PoWR conflate the truth about the existence and attributes of a [patriarchal] God with traditional epistemic approaches grounded in [narrow methodological approaches to knowledge].
6. By focusing on narrow methodologies and abstract conceptions of knowledge, WR and PoWR fail to consider ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings.

A central point in the above argument is that WR and PoWR have silenced marginalized groups. These include women, people of color, disabled persons and members of the LGBTQI+ community. As stated above, the reason for this is because traditional epistemology focuses on abstract conceptions of knowledge and thereby fails to consider the ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings. We might think however, that the argument rests on a notion of rules bias. Namely that by using certain conversational rules in philosophical discourse, that PoWR and WR silence minority groups due to their failing in some way to abide by these rules of discourse.

To see how this is the case, we can use the grammar contrast. Here, we assume that a person can learn grammar and we exclude them from the larger conversation until they do. But this would be an unfair response to the above argument. On the one hand, we could argue that it is grounded in a misreading of the argument, that minority voices are excluded from the philosophical lexicon not because they have failed to abide by the rules of philosophical discourse, but because either 1) their topics of concern fall outside the margin of interest, or 2) because of some varying identifying physical characteristic, such as failure to develop a 'rational' argument as determined by the implied narrow rules of discourse. But this would be a misrepresentation of the above argument.

The way I understand Peppers-Gates argument, is that marginalized groups have been excluded from philosophical discourse because of certain hermeneutic challenges, namely the way they are *understood* as having failed to abide by the rules of philosophical discourse. Therefore, we can amend the above argument in the following way:

1. TE focuses on abstract conceptions of knowledge.
2. PoWR grounds itself in TE by focusing on 'rational' belief in its debates about God's existence and attributes.
3. Therefore PoWR ignores feminist philosophers and philosophers of race who challenge PoWR's rules which are grounded in TE.
4. As such, WR and PoWR have silenced marginal groups.
5. PoWR's embrace of its narrow methodology and range of topics then is based in an exclusion of 'others' from meaning making in institutional philosophy.

The final premise then says that the narrow methodology employed by PoWR is not a natural methodology, but is rather exclusive in its construction. Meaning that it is narrow specifically for the purposes of excluding minority views and opinions within the lexicon. As such, I understand that the paper defends the following conclusion:

The Philosophy of Western Religion focuses on rational belief and conflates this with evolving and misapplied lexical rules in its debates about the existence and attributes of a patriarchal God.

3.3 Silencing

Western religion and the philosophy of religion have silenced marginalized groups by focusing on abstract conceptions of knowledge which fail to consider ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings. This is because traditional epistemology focuses on abstract conceptions of knowledge. These abstract conceptions of knowledge are inadequate because they do not analyze the ways power shapes our lives as “embodied social beings”. We are born in webs of meaning and social relations of power and privilege. Some voices are heard, meaning they pass review, and therefore shape the social imagination. Others are ignored however. These others then are incapable of shaping the social imagination.

On the one hand, a defense of the traditional power structure would make sure to emphasize what it means to participate in the sort of debate that does have the potential to shape the social imagination. How is one’s voice heard? One way is through the enforcement of so-called grammar rules. Taking an art class, the professor attempts to communicate the rules which apply to a given art genre. However, the students note the many deviations from these rules, the supposed exceptions. The professor then replies by saying that “once you know how to apply the rules, then you are allowed to break the rules”. An imagined analogy would be a reviewer rejecting a paper for the alleged abuse of grammar rules that a more seasoned author would be allowed to bend. A concern here is one where the so-called rules are being inappropriately applied as a means of gate-keeping who gets to shape the ‘social-imagination’. A student who fails to learn the rules, is not accepted into the art community, where work is posted in galleries, sold at auctions, is not publicly (positively or negatively) reviewed etc,. Of additional importance here, is that assuming a more seasoned author is justified in bending the lexical rules of philosophical discourse, than the more seasoned author can also be seen as contributing to the development of the lexicon rules surrounding philosophical discourse. As such, the more seasoned professional is allowed to shape the rules of discourse, and thereby contribute to the social imagination.

As such, the harm which ought to concern us here includes the exclusion of individuals from the generally shared social understanding. Excluding voices in this way contributes to their harm or can be used as a weapon to harm individual. But what is this weapon and how specifically does it as a weapon cause harm? In the following section, I will show how participation in the shared lexical structure has been called a marker of humanity. Therefore gatekeepers undermine the process by which a person becomes human.

3.4 Hermeneutic Injustice

1. When DSS (Dominant Social Structure) of meaning exclude you or distort your experiences, and no social concepts that you recognize capture your vision of yourself, then your capacity as a knower and your own self-understanding have been stunted.
 1. But this introduces a very narrow vision of social structure. Isn't it possible that while you are excluded from a dss, a non-dss, one that includes you and does not distort your experiences, could still capture a vision of yourself, and your capacity as a knower and fortifying your self-understanding.
 2. What is needed then is a new non-dss, education.
 3. While a person is excluded from a dss, they could have their capacity as a knower fortified by a non-dss, education reimagined.

The need to reimagine education.

1. WR and PoR become DSS's of meaning and exclude some or distort their experiences
2. But this introduces a very narrow vision of social structure.
 1. It is possible that while you are excluded from a dss, a non-dss, one that includes you and does not distort your experiences, could still capture a vision of yourself, and your capacity as a knower and fortifying your self-understanding.
 2. So while a person is excluded from a dss, they could have their capacity as a knower fortified by a non-dss.
3. Therefore 2 this does not mean that there are no social concepts that you recognize and capture your vision of yourself and your capacity as a knower and your own self-understanding are stunted but not by the DSS, but the lack of the non-dss.

3.4.1 One Possible example of hermeneutic injustice against religious minorities

Secular community marginalization against people of religious faith.

1. PoRF may lack 'sensibilities and resources needed to make sense of religious people's experiences,' (Kidd, 20217).
2. But does not capture gravity of systemic cases of hermeneutical injustice whose targets experience multiple forms of injustice.
 1. Hermeneutical marginalization "entails marginalization of a socioeconomic sort', targets will not 'participate on equal terms within the practices of law, academia, politics, religion, journalism, media, etc. (Fricker, 2010).

2. However, DSS vs. non-DSS? While DSS of meaning may distort experiences, non-dss may not, instead rejecting dss of meaning which says that “there are no social concepts which capture a religious person’s vision of themselves (i.e., made in image of God, human dignity bestowed by God, not DSS, etc.)”. Consider the following claims:
3. Here, Fricker, a published philosopher, the DSS, says persons of a certain sort are marginalized and therefore have been silenced. But here, marginalization means they lack a marker of humanity. As such, Fricker claims that certain individuals lack a marker of humanity.
4. Why? For not adhering to rules of rationality practiced by the dss. Surely they could however do so?
5. Because of 1, they lack participation in shared meaning.
6. Therefore lack capacity as knowers.
7. From 3, their self-understanding is mitigated and stunted.
8. Participation in shared hermeneutic, i.e., 1-4, in shared conceptual structure is a marker of humanity”,
9. Therefore, because of exclusion from shared conceptual structure, they lack a marker of humanity.

but rather than ‘victims’ being excluded from shared conceptual structure and lacking capacity as knowers and lacking marker of humanity, they instead are included in different conceptual structure (e.g., religious conceptual structure) which fortifies their capacity as knowers and self-understanding, acting as marker of humanity.

4 Patricia Collins Black Feminist Thought

In the 2009 version of Collin's Black Feminist Thought, BFT, Collins draws greater emphasis between relationships of knowledge and power. It is often said

- that knowledge = power,

but a worrying theme throughout the book, is that this is wrong and that rather

- power = knowledge.

One might notice the misapplication of a logical principle here, because whenever we use the equals sign, there is not a logical difference between $\text{power} = \text{knowledge}$ and $\text{knowledge} = \text{power}$.

Rather, this says that power is identical in value to knowledge and if power is identical to knowledge, then knowledge is identical to power.

In other words, the initial application claims that the direction of fit is not directional but rather than uni- or bi-directional.

For instance, we could look at some possible relationships between knowledge and power below:

- knowledge $\rightarrow$ power

or

- power $\rightarrow$ knowledge

or

- knowledge $\leftrightarrow$ power

Initially, we might think that assuming that if one has knowledge then the correct state of affairs should be that they will fulfill their aims, whatever those may be. This is often a selling point for higher education.

This is a common position in what is lauded as "African American Studies". Often times these positions are wrapped in the language of "struggle". While Collins notes that this "struggle" is a struggle for empowerment, it is not particularly clear who the struggle is directed at. She

argues that the struggle is global and transcendent, and she defines it as one for “survival.” But she expands the target in the most recent edition of her book to include recent developments in the areas of sexuality and “sexual politics” of black womanhood.

This is the naive view:

It can perhaps be with a bit of irony that one pursues the study of African American literary critiques. At once, these critiques are leveled against a system that is responsible for their own publishing. Frantz Fanon’s, we might naively say, is one such example. It is perhaps uncouth to look at a book’s publishers in an effort to more fully understand the semantic content of that book. Explanations of how the book came to exist are not thought to lend much support in assessing the validity of an author’s claims. Unfortunately however, the temptation to do so can be quite overwhelming at times.

Perhaps there are reasons why an understanding of the processes surrounding a book’s existence are an important part of the existence of that book, for instance the Western education of the author, the book’s distribution, the retail outlets, libraries, and classrooms, that represent the demand for the book.

Naively, I might be led to think that without any of these artifacts of a culture, that a given book would not exist. More important however, are those specific motivations that go into the book’s creation. The demands of the editor, positive reviews by reviewers, a public’s insistence that such a book needs to be written. Lastly, there is a worry that only certain authors can write a given book, such that if anyone else were to write it, it would not be received by publishers, editors, or the public.

A similar critique here is Frantz Fanon’s exploration of the effects of colonialism in the psychology of Africans. Of concern both for Fanon’s work as well as Jackson (2020), it can be difficult to disentangle what might be considered a person’s culture in isolation from the affects of colonialism. I myself am sceptical that such a project could be successful.

To read a word like Fanon’s *Black Skin, White Masks*, then, for someone as unsophisticated as myself, can be quite a daunting task. In the foreword, written by Anthony Appiah, it is claimed *Masks* is confronting the psychological affects of racism. This is an important point, given that Fanon himself is trained as a psychologist. However, Fanon begins the introduction using colonial expressions of old world notions of blackness as objects devoid of personhood. These expressions prove to me to be quite difficult obstacles to surmount.

The books target initially then is “black” empowerment which would involve the acquisition of knowledge. The problem with the above however, is that any correlation between knowledge and power is wrong from a Christian world view. Rather one is grounded in power if they have humility. “The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom.” Collins mentions the 19th century black feminist scholar Maria Stewart, noting that she urged self-reliance and independence and that her work was suppressed along with many other black feminist scholars of the era. However, we as a society know a lot more about the importance of community and inter-personal relationships, a fact which Stewart herself draws attention to:

This is a common position in what is lauded as “African American Studies”. Often times these positions are wrapped in the language of “struggle”. While Collins notes that this “struggle” is a struggle for empowerment, it is not particularly clear who the struggle is directed at. She argues that the struggle is global and transcendent, she defines the struggle as one for “survival.” But she expands the target in this edition to include recent developments of sexuality and “sexual politics” of black womanhood.

Here, the implication is not on knowledge, knowledge without wisdom is useless and a fool’s errand, it does not lead to “empowerment”. As noted in the feminist and social epistemology literature, there are many divergent accounts of knowledge and while the discourse may focus on one account of knowledge as being central to empowerment, they are often missing other accounts of the importance of knowledge. Collins mentions the 19th century black feminist scholar Maria Stewart, noting that she urged self-reliance and independence and that her work was suppressed along with many other black feminist scholars of the era. However, we as a society know a lot more about the importance of community and inter-personal relationships, a fact which Stewart herself draws attention to:

You have souls committed to your charge. . . . It is you that must create in the minds of your little girls and boys a thirst for knowledge, the love of virtue, . . . and the cultivation of a pure heart.

Here, an important development is that Stewart draws a deep connection between knowledge and virtue.

5 On Greek Tragedy

5.1 Three Kinds of Tragic Conflict

1. Good people being ruined because of things that just happen to them, things they do not control.
2. Good people doing bad things, things opposite of their ethical character and commitments because of things they do not control.
3. Good people doing bad things without direct physical compulsion and opposite of their ethical character and commitments though done in light of circumstances of equally bad choices.

Agammenon is waiting on the shore with his entire fleet. He intends to carry out a directive from Zeus to avenge his brother whose wife ran away with Paris, prince of Troy. However, because of an earlier transgression against Artemis, Artemis is holding back the wind, stranding his fleet. Agammenon, as the result of an omen of an eagle devouring a hare, is told that in order to appease Artemis, he must sacrifice his daughter Iphigenia.

As such, Agammenon is faced with two impossible choices, fail to carry out Zeus's command, or kill his daughter. It is important to point out that the fleet is already facing starvation being stranded on the coast.

However, Agammenon's sin, is not that he chooses sacrificing his daughter, instead it is the way he sacrificed his daughter.

- Like in the biblical story of Abraham, a good man must kill an innocent child "out of obedience to a divine command" [35].
- Agammenon's sin however, is not the choice, but rather how the choice was made:
 - Agammenon now begins to cooperate inwardly with necessity, arranging his feelings to accord with his fortune.
 - From the moment he makes his decision, itself the best he could have made, he strangely turns himself into a collaborator, a willing victim [35].

Progression of loss of agency:

- Necessity of the act
- to the rightness of the act
- to the rightness of the feelings of the act

6 Morality as Privilege

Montaque Reynolds (Stetson University)

6.1 Abstract

This concerns an interesting and popular assertion, that it takes a certain amount of material wealth to be a good person. I suspect that this is a project of capitalism: buy our stuff or you will be a bad person . . .

7 The Virtue of Luck (a reading of luck and ethics from Fragility of Goodness)

What is the relationship between human virtue and environmental variables? In order for a trait to be the virtue of a human being, some would like to say that it has to represent choices, rationality, actions, beliefs. However, often times these depend on environmental variables which we do not control. Most importantly among these are the values that we hold dear to us. Whether or not we recognize the importance of close relationships for instance. However, if the luck question is accurate, even these values depend on factors that are outside of our control. Our fragility, need for loved ones, friendship, etc., can at one time depend on whether or not we've encountered sufficient hardships for instance, but even outside the experience of hardships, friendships, which are also external and an environmental variable at once hold intrinsic importance, although these are external to us. As such "human goodness is nourished, even constituted, by external happenings". [1-2]

8 On Greek Tragedy

8.1 Three Kinds of Tragic Conflict

1. Good people being ruined because of things that just happen to them, things they do not control.
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- Agammenon's sin however, is not the choice, but rather how the choice was made:
 - Agammenon now begins to cooperate inwardly with necessity, arranging his feelings to accord with his fortune.
 - From the moment he makes his decision, itself the best he could have made, he strangely turns himself into a collaborator, a willing victim [35].

Progression of loss of agency:

- Necessity of the act
- to the rightness of the act
- to the rightness of the feelings of the act

8.1.1 The vulnerability of the Good Human Life

All human excellence requires external resources and necessary conditions.

- External objects to exercise virtues towards
- External objects to receive our virtues

The most important of these require relational virtues.

E.g.,

- Good activities of citizenship
- Political attachment
- Personal love
- Friendship

8.1.1.1 The Relational Harm of Slavery

Good character requires civic activity, good political surroundings.

A slave however, lacks:

- choice
- *philia*

A person needs to be able to make free and un-coerced choices. A slave is unable to do so since he belongs to someone else who makes choices for him. Owing to his inability to make free and unconstrained choices, a slave is unable to use their capacity for practical reason, choosing objects for their own sake. As such, they cannot share in *philia* which “is based on mutual respect for choice and character” [348].

9 Narrative Regrets in Truth and Fiction

God as the Best Possible Epistemic Ground of Human Dignity

Following @gold09's short paper *Narrative Thinking, Emotion, and Planning*, I consider the representation of emotional expressions of regret, *narrative regret*. I draw specific attention to the context of the representation of distinct special relationships in fiction. Important here are discourses on the fictional representation of such relationships as a special kind of human agency. I argue that a related concern are the assumptions about what is true and what is fiction in popular fiction, where what is true are expressions of relational sanctification that is grounded in a divine union of love appropriate to friendship.

10 Introduction

Wendy Laybourn (2018) draws a comparison between black authenticity and what she calls commodified realness. According to Laybourn, identity is sold to a broader public as black authenticity. This criticism is centered around the effects of what she calls *controlling images* in popular media. Of deep concern here, is that many of the members of the communities depicted by such images, consider aspects of these images to be authentic representations of themselves and the communities in which they live. Therefore, there is a public perception that such images are not in themselves harmful. If they are in some degree controlling, then they would be harmful, but there is strong disagreement regarding whether or not they are authentic representations of the communities and people they describe (20C History Project 2014; Collins 2006, 2009; Sartwell 1998).

At an organized protest in 1993, the Reverend Calvin Butts drew attention to what he called “vulgar and offensive” music. I suspect that at once this debate is no longer interesting in the halls of academia. Given that there were two passionately opposing sides to the debate, and like any debate, there are winners and there are losers, the Reverend Calvin Butts appears to have lost. While many may object to this characterization, asking what it might look like instead for Butts to have won, they will conclude that in fact we’ve all won.

However, this would be based on a unfounded characterization of the central issues of importance. Instead, the important issue has to do with the metaphysical assumptions we use when developing our understanding of personhood as applicable to ourselves. I consider the hermeneutic implications of this puzzle grounded in one’s moral epistemology. First, it is not clear just specifically which aspects of the member’s lives are being represented in fictional content. Second, it is also not clear which images are harmful considering that such images are accepted as representative (See Smitherman 1997; Shusterman 2007; Lindsey 2013). Collins (2006); and Collins (2009) has placed much emphasis on this later point. Unfortunately, this specific interpretation of her work has not achieved the recognition in the epistemology literature that it deserves.

Taking Miranda Fricker (2007)’s work on epistemic injustice, there is a conceptual space to understand the affects of the kinds of controlling images articulated by Collins. The primary accounts of epistemic justice focus on testimonial, whether or not a person’s testimony is accepted, and hermeneutic injustices, whether or not knowledge is attributed to the victim. Unlike general accounts of knowledge however, moral knowledge has often been understood as a special kind of second-person perception (Arpaly 2004; Hills 2009; Martha Craven Nussbaum 1990; Martha C. Nussbaum 2001; Fletcher 2016; Howard 2018; Sliwa 2017 among others).

On the one hand then, a form of epistemic injustice occurs when the wrong values are attributed to a victim because of they fail to accept the testimony of the victim. On the other hand, a form of epistemic injustice occurs when the audience is prevented from understanding the victim because the victim is incomprehensible to the audience, while the audience does listen to the testimony of the victim, the victim is unable to communicate their actual meaning back to the audience. It may be the case, for instance, that the victim is attempting to communicate certain value concepts to the audience. But the audience is unable to attribute these concepts to anything the victim would intend to communicate. Therefore, if Collins is correct, a person becomes a victim when members of a community fail to attribute value concepts to a victim on account of some irrelevant non-communicative feature. An example of this practice is the belief that nuclear households are a “structural mechanism of White hetero-patriarchal family supremacy” (Letiecq 2024) rather than a potentially universally shared value devoid of racial connotations. On this account, denying the existence of non-white nuclear households would be committing acts of epistemic injustice to non-whites who happen to value their nuclear families.

But if we consider moral knowledge accounts, testimony is grounded in emotional expressions of reactive attitudes. Here, we derive a particular understanding of a person’s accepted values from the way he or she responds to a particular state of affairs. Such accounts characterize moral knowledge, specifically, as a kind of feeling, or an apt emotional response to an event or action (Harrison 2011). This harm occurs when we fail to attribute a particular emotional experience to someone on account of some non-relevant / non-personal feature of who they are. An example would be denying that someone experiences heartbreak on the dissolution of his or her relationship. Therefore, it is to deny a given phenomenal experience to an individual on account of the non-relevant feature. As such, this specific epistemic harm is two fold. Not only are others prevented from (morally) understanding the victim, the victim is potentially prevented from (morally) understanding herself, she is unable to truly understand what her values are. In other words, others are prevented from understanding who she is, and she is prevented from understanding who she herself is.

Although it would be important to carve out specifically just in which ways the epistemology literature misses these points, I think that it will be more fruitful to provide a way to mitigate these harms. An important question here has to do with the relationship between popular narratives that contain these images and personal identity. One approach, *narrative identity*^{*}, argues that we are defined by the stories we accept about ourselves. Therefore at the center of the response, is an account of how victims can choose their own stories.

Important here are narratives as the representation of humanity in artifacts of culture. Some similar examples of this criticism can be found in Mbembe (2017)’s *Critique of Black Reason* or Zakiyyah Iman Jackson (2020). Jackson (2020), for instance, uses the view of race as a social construct. According to this view, ‘black’ represents a void of reason and a surplus of animality. It is not clear what the counter to this claim should be as it is not represented anywhere in either work.

A similar critique here is Frantz Fanon's exploration of the effects of colonialism in the psychology of Africans. Of concern both for Fanon's work as well as Jackson's, is that it can be difficult to disentangle what might be considered a person's culture in isolation from the affects of colonialism. I myself am sceptical that such a project could be successful. Both Jackson and Fanon repeat the claim that to be black is to be devoid of personhood, but they are deriving such assertions from colonial perceptions and it is not clear why these need to be frequently repeated.

Such views are not objective, but rather subjective through the eyes of another. Fanon and Jackson are viewing themselves through the eyes of another and a better way to develop a self-understanding, is to first focus on the self in abstraction from other perspectives. Eleonore Stump (2010) in her book "Wandering in Darkness" calls this psychic disintegration, a person has desires that they themselves do not endorse. Sanctification in love, which is a sanctification that is grounded in the integration of the good, gives power to a human person to will their own good. Unfortunately, I do not have the space to give professor Stump (2010)'s view the full weight of scholarship that it deserves and for this reason, I will address it in a future article. For now, it is important to focus on the fact that the narrative identity literature in general, gives us reason to believe that the self can be discovered and cultivated through narratives.

As such, I look at three important narratives for how an understanding of the self could be derived by looking at a fundamental part of self, namely regret and its objects. After highlighting some examples regarding the expression of regret in popular media, I provide a summary of the literature on narrative identity. I suggest that *narrative identity** is a better alternative. I then propose what I call narrative regret as a necessary component of 'narrative identity*'.

I compare three songs as quintessential examples of narrative regret; *By yourself* by Ty Dolla \$ign, a song about financial and relational independence and *Rich and Sad* by Post Malone, and *Insecure No More* by Alex Jean. The protagonist in *by yourself* is praised for her ability to sever her relational ties without regret from a partner who is unwilling or unable to financially contribute to that relationship. In contrast, the song *Rich and Sad* by Post Malone is a song about relational dependence where the protagonist expresses his regret at pursuing wealth and other material possessions rather than a special relationship. In contrast to the two, Jean in *Insecure* uses regret to express ways in which he reclaims his human agency. As examples of narrative regret, I consider whether one is more expressive of human agency than the other.

11 Robust vs. Generic Expressions of Regret

What is the difference between harm done in regard to someone's capacity as a knower and their capacity as a 'moral' knower? In part, this is a relation between the victim's capacity as a moral knower, and the victim's capacity *as a person*, where personhood denotes more specifically, their own moral agency, held values, and the like. Patricia Collin's work is central to contemporary literature on standpoint epistemology precisely because of the possible implications for self-knowledge and moral agency (See Collins 2006; and Collins 2009). Of little notice however, are her contributions to questions about authenticity and representation and where these intersect with moral agency.

Discussions following Miranda Fricker's work are centered around the moral wrongs of epistemic injustice. These are defined as wrongs of testimonial inference where the victim is wronged in their capacity as an epistemic knower (Especially see Fricker 2007, 44). The victim's credibility as an epistemic agent is diminished and as such, she is made unintelligible to a broader public. However, the wrongs do not draw enough attention to a specific kind of moral harm. Here, 'moral' implies 'moral' information, or 'moral' knowledge and self-knowledge or understanding.

Fricker hints at the moral non-moral implication by drawing attention to cases where an agent's epistemic contributions are diminished when she notes that "the epistemic wrong bears a social *meaning* to the effect that the subject is less than fully human" (Fricker 2007, 44). While Fricker emphasizes the word 'meaning', the proper emphasis is on the word *social*, drawing instead to the word '*social meaning*' as the proper focus of the epistemic wrong.

For instance, Emma Magnus and Malone (2023) gives such an account by highlighting the criminal prosecutions that cite song lyrics as testimonial confessions. Malone argues that being too generous in treating artistic assertions as truth in songs, commits the harm of art-interpretive injustice. She argues that the listener, in this case the prosecution, extends the wrong degree of credibility to the artist. Instead of interpreting the song lyrics as art, the listener interprets the lyrics as testimony.

Importantly, a component of Malone's argument is that prosecutions do not treat other genres of music based on the content of their art. However, there is another and more important issue at concern here. This worry is found in the dual character account of art Malone has previously defended. There, Malone argues that *authentic* country music is a dual character art-form that embodies "the core value commitments of the genre" (*Rich and Sad* 2018, 1). According to this view, country music, like punk rock and hip-hop (Liao, Meskin, and Knobe 2020) constitute core value commitments. As such, following the dual character account of

art, it is not clear what level of credibility we should assign to the song lyrics in criminal prosecutions.

Consider the following dialogue used by Liao, Meskin, and Knobe (2020), 7-8:

11.0.0.1 The Scientist

Alfie: She is not a scientist. I know many people think she is a scientist, but when you think about what scientists really are, you will realize that she is not a scientist at all.

Betty: Of course she is a scientist. She is skilled at running experiments and publishing in scientific journals.

Alfie: That is not what I meant! What I meant is that she does not possess a genuine willingness to revise her beliefs in light of empirical evidence.

11.0.0.2 The Christian

Alfie: She is not a Christian. I know many people think she is a Christian, but when you think about what it really means to be a Christian, you will realize that she is not a Christian at all.

Betty: Of course she is a Christian. She goes to church every week and believes that Jesus is the son of God.

Alfie: That is not what I meant! What I meant is that she does not show genuine compassion.

According to Liao *et al*, we can “pick out the concepts” for which people make various judgments as those above by distinguishing them from the kinds of judgments for which people would not make similar judgments. Here, many things will both satisfy and at the same time fail to satisfy criteria allowing one to make identity judgments such as ‘christian’ or ‘scientist’. These enable one to judge whether someone *truly* belongs to a given category.

Malone follows Liao, Meskin, and Knobe (2020) who argue that we can “pick out the concepts” for which people make various judgments as those above by distinguishing them from the kinds of judgments “from concepts for which people would not make such judgments” (Liao, Meskin, and Knobe 2020, 6). Here, many things will both satisfy and at the same time fail to satisfy the criteria that allows one to make identity judgments. I argue that here, as a character attribution, these concepts enable one to judge whether someone *truly* belongs to a given category.

11.1 Testimonial and Hermeneutical Injustice

Here, art injustice is treated as a form of testimonial injustice. Listeners “extend the wrong degree of credibility”, then the testimony of the speaker is called into question because of the identity of the speaker. In *people v. medina*, Alex Medina was accused of murdering Seth Scarminach. In the case, the prosecution attempted to use song lyrics performed by Medina as an admission of guilt. When Alex Medina was tried for murder, he experienced an art interpretive injustice because “In cases like Medina’s, the rapper is either not deemed to have produced a work of art at all or deemed presumptively to have produced art which is confessional”. As such, Medina’s lyrics were treated as confessional rather than a work of art. But Medina does not suffer from credibility deficit, hermeneutic injustice, because his lyrics were used as credible evidence. Although Medina was employing artistic license, he was not treated as though he was.

Hermeneutic injustice, unlike testimonial injustice, occurs “when someone’s own experience is obscured because the available concepts distort it or render it inscrutable”. Yet, as a counter to Malone, Medina’s case can also be one of hermeneutic injustice. Important to this point, is that social experiences are “obscured from collective understanding”. This is caused by the structural identity prejudice in the “collective hermeneutic” resource. Important here, is the fact that analogous to the Medina case, it is highly likely that audiences misdescribe the victim’s narrative experiences, reinterpreting regret as empowerment [See Fricker (2007); 169].

12 Practical Identity (Narrative Identity)

In previous work, Malone (2023) argues that country music allows its audiences to “reconnect with, reify, and revise” a common *practical* identity. There is no reason to think that country music in this regard is any different than rap and hip-hop in that both genres provide opportunities for their audience to make character assessments about the members of a category.

A hermeneutic artistic injustice then is not the failure to attribute art concepts to a person’s work because of their identity; “identity prejudice and the matter at issue is the application of shared art concepts” (Magnus and Malone 2023). This is important in the conversation of black country music. But in the early epistemic literature at the start of this article, the injustice occurs when certain concepts common to a genre (love, relationship, family, community) are the cause of the identity prejudice in the “collective hermeneutic” resource. For instance, when values often associated with a given genre are the reason for denying an artist inclusion into that genre. On this account, we might explain the long time exclusion of African Americans from country music not by their race, but because we do not associate them with the kinds of values which country music promotes. Contemporary discussions argue that an artist is denied because of their race, however, while this may be true, it is important to understand the full implications here.

The failure to include an artist in a genre stems from a failure to attribute shared value concepts that would be inferred by that person’s inclusion into a given genre. As such, there are two competing versions of victimhood relevant to Medina’s case. On the one hand, Medina’s lyrics are treated as art because of a lack of remorse characteristic of the artistic genre he is a part of. On this account, his lyrics are celebrated as art and not as expressions of regret or testimony. However, on the other account of harm, instead of treating his lyrics as art, identified by the shared lack of remorse and regret common to the genre, they are treated as testimony, i.e., expressions of regret (confession) that we might think are characteristic of a more universally expressed emotion.

The social version of this question is more opaque. It is a question about our social environments and to what extent our social environments can provide us with the resources necessary to fulfill our moral obligations. What about representative expressions of a universal value, can these be characteristic expressions of regret when failing a moral obligation? Once again, there are two questions here however, the first asks how our moral obligations define us. More important, i.e., more manageable here, is the second which asks how our experiences of regret entail those obligations or entail our acceptance of our social obligations.

12.1 Identity Reductionism

Here I focus on a narrowly defined understanding of intra and extra personal character assessments. Narrative accounts of identity attempt to use the way an individual responds to events in a person's life to identify the agent through space and time. For instance, in the agency literature, reductionists explain the metaphysical continuity of an object across space and time in terms of personal identity. Derek Parfit (1987) argues that in order to understand what sort of object a person is, we need to understand two different qualities. These include the nature of a person and their *criterion of identity*, i.e., their continued existence over time. But when we consider these qualities in contrast to persons versus non-persons, we include not only physical states of matter, but also immaterial ones such as mental states, memories, beliefs, motivations, etc. A person can be identified just if continuity between subsequent immaterial mental states and physical states are achieved.

Reductionists such as Parfit can define personal identity as the persistence of the human person over time, and say that this is reducible to the binding of psychological states with physical matter. Causalism is the most popular account that explains the origin of psychological states, an object A at time T_1 is identical to object B at time T_2 as long as we can draw a continuous line from object A at time T_1 to object B at time T_2 . The continuous line here is most often mental states such as memory, passions, character traits and dispositions. But often times it is the case that those memories we accept as definitive, have their origins in persons or events other than ourselves. There are certain dispositions I have because of persons other than myself signing various documents articulating what rights I recognize as belonging to me for instance.

While Parfit's account does show how persons are not mere matter, he and other causalists state that an action performed by an agent, is an event caused by the mental state of that agent (Altshuler 2021). The difficulty arises in understanding how mental states are related to prior events. While a mental state may be the source of some event, another event may be the source of another mental state. Regardless of the relationship between mental states and the material universe, it is not clear where the causal chain originates.

In response, Christine M. Korsgaard (1989) has argued that on Parfit (1987)'s account of identity, a person is primarily a *locus of experience* (Christine M. Korsgaard 1989, 103). This means that the way to identify an object as existing through space and time as it correlates with a person, is by identifying a set of experiences between objects across space and time that are connected through a set of events or some other connecting factor. These events are psychological states and 'spatio-temporally continuous living bod[ies]' (Christine M. Korsgaard 1989, 104). In this way I might define myself as *an American* and defend such values as independence and freedom. It is plausible then to draw a line from events in 1776, America's founding, to my present day. Therefore I associate various values I hold with events that transpired in 1776 and as such, the psychological states I currently have, have their own origins centuries before. In other words, because a person's psychological states have prior causes, the states themselves are merely some form of event and experience.

Narrative accounts then are responses to impersonal accounts. According to narrative accounts, how we frame events such as these, is what makes the event meaningful for a given individual (Schechtman 1996, 96). Without narratives, the agency and the identity of the subject is lost among a causal chain of events. This has been called ‘constitution’. In terms of the constitution model of identity, without the binding effect of narrative, the subject of a given event is victim to a disparate causal chain of cause and effect. Our identity then would merely be an impersonal metaphysical continuation of matter (C. M. Korsgaard 1996).

The meanings that stories provide are not derived from the individual meanings of the events they represent, rather the individual events derive their meaning from the overall meaning of the story. The outcome of the story determines the meaning of the events within the story. Why something happened is explained by the end of the story in which it happened. But this is ascribed by the agent, that individual. The difficulty arises in understanding how mental states are related to events, whether emotional, causal or something else. The divergence not only has implications for ways in which we identify material objects persisting across space and time, but also with respect to moral attributions of praise and blame. These uniquely belong to active *immaterial* objects such as persons.

Kantians and Utilitarians have differing conceptions of agency which together represent a source of justification for either view. When concerning moral obligation and duty for instance, it is the moral agent who deserves to be praised or blamed. In this way, say my acceptance of a person’s human rights, has nothing to do with me. Utilitarians on the other hand ask ‘what should be done for the agent?’, persons with a characteristic form of experience and the Kantian asks ‘what ought the agent do?’, despite a given experience. Parfit’s account does not account for what we all might think of as the exercise of agency. As such, Korsgaard goes on to argue that focusing on what an agent does, rather than their experiences, will lead to a drastically different concept of identity, one that is grounded in a unique characterization of agency. She calls this characterization ‘practical’ identity.

Korsgaard then, defends a concept of narrative identity. Reductionist and causalist conceptions of identity undermine what we think of as agency with regard to moral responsibility. These accounts fail to explain the attribution of praise or blame in response to an agent’s actions. They offer no way to define the line as beginning at T_1 and ending at T_2 . On this account, the object, that persistent thing deserving of either moral praise or blame, is indefinable.

On her narrative account of identity, a person is an agent who uses narrative to define her own constitution. She calls this the *self*-constitution model of personal identity. As such, Korsgaard defends an account of personhood and identity grounded in narrative agency. On this account, we are defined by the stories we accept about ourselves. The act of acceptance means that we select individual events from our pasts in order to construct a narrative that defines us.

As an explanation, narrative theories provide one account of personhood by explaining the relationship of cause and event in a way that preserves agency. Stories make our lives intelligible (Velleman 2003) by providing motive and context to a collection of events and episodes. In

other words, narrative gives meaning to otherwise meaningless events. Overall, the meanings that stories provide are not derived from the individual meanings of the events they represent. Rather, the individual events derive their meaning from the overall meaning of the story. The outcome of the story determines the meaning of the events within the story. Finally, the meaning of the outcome is determined by the story teller. Why something happened is explained by the end of the story in which it happened.

The second question is even more difficult and grounds the first. It begins as a question about ourselves and the sources of our beliefs as to what is possible. Peter Goldie (2009) convincingly argues that we would not experience regret for an event that we had no control over the same way we would for an event we did have control over. It will first be helpful to understand how narrative theories shape our identities.

12.2 Constitutionalism reconfigured (Narrative Identity*)

Altshuler identifies a problem with the above account, namely that it does not account for those events that are not selected by the agent. He argues that such events do have a causal effects on what ultimately constitutes one's identity. Following Peter Goldie (2009), Altshuler instead identifies narrative with an agent's *ability* to reconfigure their motivational and psychological past with respect to their own reactions to these events. In other words, Altshuler too, defends a self-constitution model of agency and identity, but one on which a person's responses to his or her past, shape her future identity.

Altshuler responds to the reductionistic identity problem by expanding Korsgaard's analysis. On his account then, we are defined by the stories we accept about ourselves, which is determined by our reflexive rather than reflective endorsements. This reflexive endorsement is determined by emotions we express upon our reflection on our narratives. Since on Altshuler's account it is possible for the agent to give an accounting for all of the experiences she has by the way of reflexive endorsement or rejection, this account does not disregard important agent forming experiences. Therefore, his account is grounded in a more comprehensive description of how the agent goes about selecting events that self-prescribe their identity.

The locus of the reduction is hard to pin down in the context of the kinds of desires expressed by an entity as complex as a human person. An analogous complexity can be found in many popular love songs. Although a murky concept, narratives offer a promising way to better understand causal and psychological reductionism. This is because they can incorporate and give shape to "a wide range of heterogeneous" mental states and events (Altshuler 2021). By giving shape to these factors, narrative theories explicate an agent's motivations as a response to environmental effects.

12.2.1 Narrative production in context

It is important to point out that comparing narrative identity accounts and popular narratives conflates two different understandings of ‘narrative’. We might think that *narratives* are insufficient for the kinds of narrative portrayed by Altshuler and Korsgaard. Such narratives then are not controlling in the way Laybourn argues that they are.

Although narrative offers promise, it is also not clear how we might recognize a narrative in the wild, what does a sample narrative look like? Focusing on the expressions of regret in some popular songs may provide one answer. If some songs are narratives, the expressions of regret in them may provide a response to psychological and causal reductionism. As we saw earlier, love songs or anti-love songs can express regret for when the relationship ends, or regret for the relationship not ending sooner; which is another way for thinking about how the narrator’s life may have gone differently.

What is important about the expression of the feeling of regret here, is what that experience does for the agent’s behavior going forward in the context of the meaning that the narrative gives to that event, or the agent derives from it. Love songs could be a form of narrative thinking in both the philosophical context and the popular one. Importantly here however, love songs might be a process by which someone organizes their experience and creates their own identity (Schechtman 1996).

As such, the second kind of question is a question about what we believe to be true about ourselves. Related to this then is a question about what extent do our environments contribute to our beliefs about what is true about ourselves, including our moral and other obligations. Here I suggest then that how we should understand such questions, who we are, is in the form of narrative regrets. How we should understand art then, is as a way of exploring expressions of narrative regret.

Even more important for our context of identity, this narrative thinking is always done in the context of self-other relationships. As such, the emotion of love is important, and regret is important for understanding the importance of love for self-identity. Without this particularly self-other relational thinking rooted in love, it is difficult for the victim to develop an authentic understanding of who she is.

12.3 Regret and Other Popular Music Forms

It is possible that when a song expresses regret for not having met someone sooner, they are thinking about how their life might have gone had they married sooner. The marriage itself is not meaningful for the individual as a stand-alone event. Rather, the marriage only has causal influence on the subsequent events of that person’s life and it is the person who defines the event in such a way to make it a meaningful marker of their own identity. It is where the marriage sits in the overall context of the course of a given relationship for instance. A

marriage event in the context of a short and harmful relationship has a very different meaning than one in the context of a long and loving relationship. Most importantly however, it is important in the context of the meaning that a person derives from the event.

Many popular songs are saturated in the emotion of regret. In such contexts, the narrative expresses a negative emotion in response to something a character in the narration did, or that was done to them.

In *The Grand Tour*, the narrator as character expresses regret at having lost a significant other while the song *He Stopped Loving Her Today*, the narrator, giving a narrative account of someone else also expresses the regret felt by the character when their relationship dissolves. The above are emblematic country songs in that regret is commonly expressed in country music. Different songs express regret in different contexts however. *Apologize* by Timbaland is not a country song, and expresses regret in a different context. Here the narrator expresses regret for the love that he, the narrator, *had* felt.

Love songs often express regret when a relationship ends. In the song *The Grand Tour*, our attention is drawn to the daily use of items “where she used to . . .” which speak to the fact that they were once shared by people who experienced positive sentiments toward one another. Their current state however suggests that they are no longer used this way “. . . this old house will never be the same . . .”. In *The Grand Tour*, there is existing controversy over whether the end of the relationship is caused by the narrator, or someone else. In the podcast *Cocaine and Rhinestones: The history of country music*, Tyler Mahan Coe suggests that the change in the state of the lives of the individuals involved in *The Grand Tour* is the result of a tragic mishap citing these lines in the song; “There’s her rings, all her things, and her clothes are in the closet” and “as you leave you’ll see the nursery, . . . taking nothing but the baby and my heart”.

The events in *The Grand Tour* may not have been caused by the involvement from any agent. For instance, if Coe is correct, then the dissolution of the relationship depicted in *The Grand Tour* has nothing to do with any actions committed on the part of the narrator or his lost love. In *He Stopped Loving Her Today*, the regret is more definitively caused by an action when the subject whom the song speaks about is left by their significant other effectively dissolving their relationship. “He said I’ll love you ‘till I die, She told him ‘you’ll forget in time’”. Regret can be the result of either an action or an event and the regret in *The Grand Tour* is likely caused by an event, whereas in Jones’ other song, *He Stopped Loving Her Today*, it is likely caused by an action for instance if the protagonist pursued undisclosed intimate relationships with others.

While in the two previous examples *regret* is expressed upon the end of a relationship or rather its dissolution, in other examples, more positive emotions, not regret, are expressed upon the end or dissolution of the relationship rather than of the relationship’s continuance. For instance Kelly Clarkson’s *Since U Been Gone* does this: “Since you’ve been gone, I can breath for the first time . . .”. There are also different reasons for the regret whether expressed for having suffered through the ordeal of that relationship, or for its end. Sometimes the regret

is expressed as a longing for various qualities the loved possessed, for instance in the *Grand Tour*, “over there, sits the chair ... and whisper ‘oh I love you’”. For these reasons, narratives can help us to feel closeness and union with those the loved even though they are fictional. This correlates with expressions of emotion associated with love, where love has often been defined as the feeling of loving emotions provoked in one party by another. Upon the object’s absence, the subject no longer feels these emotions and experiences regret on account of this absence (Taylor 1976). The lover can also experience regret in longing for the qualities not possessed by the loved, when someone whom they loved failed to reciprocate in word or deed, or failed in some other way. For instance in Timbaland’s *Too Late to Apologize* the following line expresses this: “tell me that you need me then you go and cut me down”.

At the center of the difference between popular narratives like those found in popular songs, and narrative identity accounts is that popular narratives are merely ones we are prompted to imagine (Gilmore 2020, 132). But the source of narrative identities is not clear. The question then is what connection do those narratives that we are prompted to imagine, have to our own narrative identities. John Gilmore (2020) suggests that the relationship is weak and dependent on the function of the imagination for engaging with the work. Patricia Hill Collins and Wendy Laybourn on the other hand suggest a strong relationship (Collins 2006, 2009; Laybourn 2018). The narratives in popular media are controlling images designed to justify racist and sexist attitudes.

Controlling images “are designed to make racism, sexism, poverty, and other forms of social injustice appear to be natural, normal, and inevitable parts of everyday life” (Collins 2009, 77).

It is important to point out here that I am not asking about purpose or the design of such prompted imaginings. Rather, focusing on Laybourn’s context of ‘authenticity’ and ‘realness’ highlights a popular implicit assumption regarding what is true and what is fiction in popular media. Peter Goldie (2009) highlights our emotions as a form of reflection, especially that of regret. Sometimes as agents, the expressions of regret enables one to better exercise their own agency. We can imagine someone being cheated through the purchase of a used car. Looking towards the future, that individual would exercise more caution as a consequence upon reflection of their mistake. In these moments, the ability to tell a story becomes important as we are enabled by the narrative to recognize the appropriate objects of our emotions in the story. Reflecting on the failed used car purchase, the subject experiences regret. This subsequent experience pushes them to exercise more caution in the future. Similarly, we can compare this to another example. Here, regret is either appropriate to aspects of the story which bear no direct relation on the narrator, or ones that do. Being able to recognize and reflect on emotions enables one to express their agency going forward. What regret is afforded to the subject when reflecting on decisions made by themselves?

In this context, narrative is substantial in our lives as it provides ways of thinking about how our lives may have gone differently, or may go differently and why; our plans for the future

and how things might turn out.¹ Thinking in this way leads to regret if we are disappointed in a particular choice we have made. Our feelings of regret can cause us to behave differently in the future. Questions about narrative thinking then just are questions about moral agency.

Importantly, the possible prospect of being able to imagine today what a morally good life will look like for us tomorrow, is a question about how what we believe about ourselves today, including what desires we have, influence our ability to pursue these ways of being. These in turn determine our regrets. Imagining what kind of person our spouse will be can perhaps open up some romantic possibilities while closing others. Imagining where we will buy our first home may restrict our career choices, just like imagining how many children we will have may affect where we want to live. But more importantly, having various beliefs about ourselves undergird all these other possibilities.

More importantly, we can develop a sense of agency when we imagine ways in which our friendships, family ties, and other important relationships will go. These are preceded by beliefs in us about ways they *could* go. We can imagine the type of person we are to others and take needed steps for becoming that person, if we believe it is possible. As such, the person we will be and how we will relate to others is the goal that is formed by a narrative. Consider one particular narrative, we imagine ourselves as thoughtful, kind, considerate, loving, or compassionate. Imagining ourselves this way becomes the motivation we need to read up on the latest parenting methods. We might imagine ourselves being invited to witness the birth of a friend's first child and scour the internet for advice on how to be a better gift giver.

While the argument that the way we imagine our lives going can have a positive causal effect on the kind of person we become, one may argue that this view is too optimistic. To what extent do the experiences we have shape the person we become? For instance, Eric J. Miller (2020) argues that victimhood imposes normative standards that ground the moral status of the victim. What he means is that social roles, such as victim, determine the values we are expected to live by.

As a victim, there are various normative standards imposed on us that undermine our ability to imagine other parenting styles and values, such as those relating to how we protect and nourish our children. Libertarian values may be those we are less apt to promote in our homes. One reason is that when victims as parents, or the parents of victims, instruct a child, they must instruct them to act in self-subordinating ways “when confronted by the police” [221] rather than in ways that assert their autonomy.

Consider the following example narratives:

- Ty Dolla's *by Yourself*: “Stacked your bread and bought your own Mercedes (Vroom, vroom). You your own boss, do it your way (Way)

¹For contrast, see Michael Bratman (2000) argues that as agents, we are purposeful and reflective about our motivations, and capable of organizing our activity over and in-line with our purposes and motivations as we reflect on them. One method of reflection involves the expressions of various emotions upon the occurrence of some event.

The song's protagonist is faced with a given environment that forces her to exert her independence rather than her social bonds. As such, her lack of regret is a normative standard imposed on her. We can contrast this situation with the possibility that while material goods may or may not be a necessary condition for well-being, they are certainly not a sufficient one as expressed in other popular songs. The protagonist in the song *Rich and Sad* by Post Malone, looks back over other events, motives, and desires that resulted in the dissolution of his relationship and he feels sadness, as an expression of regret:

- “All this stuntin’ couldn’t satisfy my soul (–oul), Got a hundred big places, but I’m still alone (–one)”.

First, each of the above narratives are constrained by beliefs the narrator may have about themselves. In the first, the narrator, believing they have no other choice but to cut themselves off from anyone who is unable to contribute financially. But it does lead to another criticism, the agency of the artist versus that of the audience. Some music criticisms will often point out that musical taste assumes a sense of moral autonomy not available to some. If an artist is accustomed to abject poverty, then that person might be seen as vulnerable to market forces, creating art that is in high demand for the purposes of financial gain (Laybourn 2018), or only capable of representing their immediate physical environment (Richardson and Scott 2002). Regret within narratives are an example of such narrative agency. But if Eric Miller is correct, then some populations just do not possess agency in the requisite sense. But this view would thoroughly undermine decades of social justice movements in law and elsewhere.

The common responses to such criticisms come in two forms. They typically make some causal claim about the effects of environment on both artistic performance (Richardson and Scott 2002), and audience music selection criteria, for instance, that artists are merely defining their personal experiences (Shusterman 2007, 419). This responses highlight unequal wealth opportunities imposing normative standards on their victims. The second kind of response makes a cultural claim deriving from supposed traditional practices in pre-colonial Africa (Abrahams 2006).

Importantly here, the responses that are grounded in assertions about the culture of pre-colonial Africa are not necessarily a response to the empirical claims about the representations of anti-social behavior in rap and hip-hop music, but rather to the metaphorical use of language exhibited by pre-colonial African tribal practices. What are commonly noted as anti-social themes in rap and hip-hop then are downplayed as word-play underlying a cultural or political critique or something else entirely. Namely the references to violence and misogyny are allegorical, not literal (Smitherman 1997; Gates 1989). What is important among these responses however, is that they too undermine attributions of personal identity and human agency and go against the dual character concept of art.

Separately, some have held that we can determine the values an artist holds, by carefully listening to the song lyrics they write. Although this fact would suggest that an artist's lyrics might qualify as a personal narrative defining an artist's identity and agency, it is not clear whether such narratives would qualify on this account of narrative agency. Although

Altshuler’s account could give more credence to music lyrics as an example narrative in the psychological sense, it is not clear how this may be the case. According to some accounts, an artist’s written lyrics and musical arrangement merely express plausible values someone might hold (*Rich and Sad* 2018), while others articulate them as more definitive (Meissner and Huebner 2022), still others argue that art is functional (Gilmore 2020), thereby leaving open the possibility they could count as narrative in the functional sense, but do not do so necessarily.

It may be that rap and hip-hop are not good example narratives. But they show promise. Consider the question above, is some material good a necessary and sufficient condition for well-being as expressed in some popular songs? As narratives, the two examples above would better explain why some event happened. Why the protagonist in *by yourself* severed their relationship with their significant other, and why the protagonist in *Rich and Sad* is rich and sad.

Here, we primarily contrast [money] as the material object expressing that it:

- “could satisfy my soul”

And contrasting this with [money] as the material object expressing that it:

- “could not satisfy my soul”.

One way that narratives are thought to explain agency then, is by synchronizing incongruous events, states, and motives. As such, a narrative can say yes, money is either a necessary and sufficient condition for well-being for some agent or not. As such, the expressions of regret offers a plausible way to recognize the core of one’s agency.

Recognizing the form of some plausible narratives may help to understand how to recognize a narrative if we say it. The various incidents and events have made it difficult for the agent to recognize value in non-material objects. We can, and often do, ask a meta-ethical question about what kinds of objects are truly of moral value and why. The narrative provides us with a plausible account of the why. For instance, we can ask to what extent the quest for consumer goods ought to outweigh other pursuits such as time with one’s children or calling one’s mother on Sunday. What is probably missing from the above is the understanding that there is a difference between only some material possession being necessary for well-being, versus some non-material possession being necessary for well-being.

But exactly how are material and non-material objects expressed over and against one another other? It may be the case that volunteering at an orphanage is of moral value and it can be expressed in song in at least two ways. Lyrically, “I wish I had volunteered at the orphanage yesterday”. Or lyrically that expresses a negative outcome for not having volunteered at the orphanage yesterday. In constructing lyrics of the second form, the author chooses words that either have been historically encoded with the sentiment she is hoping to ascribe to a state of affairs, or is potentially encoded with that sentiment in such a way that the desired emotion is potentially ascribed to that state of affairs. However, if I neglect my children in volunteering

at an orphanage, then *my* volunteering is of reduced moral value and we could imagine a lyrics saying “I wish I had spent time with my children instead of volunteering at the orphanage yesterday”, or that says “I spent so many hours at the orphanage that I do not know who my own children are anymore”; or “I spent hours at the orphanage, I do not know who my own children are anymore”.

We can also express a normative question about what behaviors are appropriate, when we should be kind, or whether a given action is more kind than another using similar methods. But there are additional interesting questions. As inferred above, we ask about the context in which a given ethical question is of moral value, and we can express it as a value by inviting the audience to reflect on such expressions by coercing their emotions accordingly. Volunteering my time at an orphanage is of moral value, and so I would use music or poetry to evoke emotions in the audience that correspond with this value. Considering the context is a way to assess the rationality of a given question, emotional expression in art is a way to make sense of that question. Making sense of the question helps us to anticipate the answer in at least two ways, what does the artist suggest is valuable, we would then look at the emotional expressions in her art, and what is the agent potentially capable of valuing.

For instance, assuming that Jill is the last sentient creature on a far away planet, it may not make sense to ask what Jill’s ethical obligations are to those around her. But contexts regarding ethical questions are important. There are two important such contexts here; socio-economic or cultural environments, and psychological or social ones. Given questions about morality, our concerns are largely about how we should behave toward others. For many years, this was answered by referencing cultural and socio-economic conditions. More controversially, it has also been answered by referencing psychological or social conditions. But this is not the same as asking whether a given question about ethical obligation makes sense or not. It would not make sense to say a person with a medical condition that precludes the experience of empathy, has an ethical obligation to experience the emotions that align with empathy. There is a way in which our questions about moral behavior should make sense. This is in the context of our behavior toward others. Most humans, will generally live in contexts wherein our behavior to others should have a kind of rationality about them, in valuing our relationships with others.

The social version of this question is more opaque. It is a question about our social environments and to what extent our social environments can provide us with the resources necessary to fulfill our moral obligations. Once again, there are two categories of question here. For instance, consider our choices as to what kind of careers would make fulfilling our moral obligations possible. If we recognize a moral obligation to give vast amounts of wealth to charity, then we could pursue a set of social connections (work hard in high school and get into a good university) that would make our ability to fulfill this obligation more likely. The other category of question is even more difficult however. It begins as a question about ourselves and the sources of our beliefs as to what is possible, and what is not. We would start with a question about what is true about ourselves. Related to this is a question about what extent do those around us contribute to our beliefs about what is true about ourselves and what is obligatory in regard to our behavior. If we consider that we have a moral obligation to support national

health, then there are some political parties we might campaign on behalf of and others we would not. Here I suggest then that how we should understand such questions is in the form of a narrative.

13 Works Cited

Part II

Drafts & Notes

14 Notes

15 Pinero

Piñero Moral (2021) argues that this is because art's purpose in the middle ages is to represent reality. It is one thing to accurately and factually represent a tree, however, Pinero is talking about more complex reality, especially moral reality. One example of medieval representations of moral reality include the Persian Manticore. The manticore as depicted in medieval art is said to represent evil.

There are several ways in which some art objects may represent more complex realities. One may think that the purpose of a painting is to reflect the experiences one had during a war, or peace time event. Such a painting may express the given facts of the case, for instance an artist could paint the signing of the Magna Carta. If the painting were painted by an artist who was alive to witness the signing of the Magna Carta, then the artist would merely be representing contemporary reality. If the artist were not alive at the time, then we could argue that the artist is representing historical reality. The artist is relying on trusted and well known sources would be different from the artist imagining an event in which not many direct sources exist. But an artist can represent a projection of reality as well when the reality they want to convey is obscure, not well known, highly contested or hypothetical.

According to this definition of medieval art, art implies metaphysical aspirations and normative elements (Also see De Bruyne 1959). Its commitment to reality is undeniable, yet the reality which it attempts to represent is so complex and vast that the limits between what is and what is not, between what we believe and what we know, between what we are and what we wish to be, are often blurred (**cron41?**).

Here, the artist can represent facts as they believe them to be, or as they wish them to be. It is this latter motivation that Pinero suggests motivated medieval artwork representing the manticore. There is a difference here then between modern and medieval artistic function. This in itself is uninteresting. However, what may be more interesting to the reader, is the further claim that this difference can be applied in response to the contemporary account of epistemic injustice.

16 Wendy Laybourn's Cost of Being Real

Research on black authenticity identifies “oppressive othering” and “white standards of beauty”, particularly lighter skin tone, as key components of commercial success in the entertainment industry.

- Oppressive Othering (commodified black authenticity, cba)
- White Standards of Beauty (wsb)

In this note, I am only going to focus on oppressive othering / commodified black authenticity, cba.

Are rap lyrics a case of oppressive othering? By using rap lyrics, Laybourn argues that we can compare oppressive othering with white standards of beauty.

However, the way she does so is by drawing attention to a positive correlation between lighter skin tone and higher Billboard chart ratings.

There wasn't a similar relation noticed between rap lyrics (oppressive othering) and higher chart ratings though at the center of this issue seems to be a suggestion that a harmful representation of blackness is sold to the public as “authentic blackness”.

Importantly, this particular commodity then “shapes” what is accepted as authentic blackness, and what is commodified as authentic blackness.

In addition to the “oppressive othering” of cba, “white standards” of beauty are also sold. But it isn't clear what correlation there is between cba and wsb if any.

Laybourn argues that both wsb and cba stem from attitudes which position blacks as an outgroup and whites as an in-group.

As such, when cbas are dangerous when they serve as an avenue for interaction with black culture and a proxy for interpersonal interaction with black Americans, even though they are created within a framework “that” reifies anti-blackness.

Of deep concern here, is that many of the members of the communities depicted by such images, consider aspects of these images to be authentic representations of themselves and of the communities in which they live. Therefore, there is a public perception that such images are not in themselves harmful. Therefore, there is strong disagreement regarding whether or not they are harmful (20C History Project 2014; Collins 2006, 2009; Sartwell

1998).

Laybourn more narrowly defines cba as one dominant group's creation of more inferior groups. This is accomplished through media portrayals linking anti-social behaviors, violence, abuse, crime, to these other groups.

17 Currie's Fiction

Why do we think that fairy tales are fiction but news stories are not? Is fake news the same thing as a fairy tale? During the pandemic, fake news became a widely discussed talking point. A less widely discussed talking point however was why don't we just call it fiction? A derivative of this question is how fiction is made possible. Meaning, what are the creative differences between fake news, news news and fairy tales? To answer this question, Gregory Currie suggests three possible answers.

According to the front page news, the terrorist leader Amelia Boyd was killed by the Head-hunters Gang. First are the characteristics that distinguish fiction from non-fiction. This question is a close investigation of the entities that are in fiction and make them possible. For instance, the psychological and linguistic resources that producers and consumers of fiction must have access to.

First, consider that fiction uses language. But there is no universal linguistic feature shared by all fictional works and there is no available proof/s confirming what is a fiction.¹ We usually think that reading a work is an act of reading words and sentences that make it up.² However, consider a mime? Or silent films? These are works that do not use language in the traditional sense, yet we consider them fictional. Therefore, what makes something a fiction cannot necessarily be a linguistic feature. Therefore what makes something a fiction is neither a necessary nor sufficient condition for being fictional. Finally then, something can be a fiction because of its verbal structure, but what makes it a fiction does not lie in the text itself.

17.1 Semantic Properties

Currie concludes that fictionality is a relational property, it is something possessed in virtue of the text's relations to other things. Therefore while it is possible that fictionality is a linguistic matter, what makes it a fiction lies in some other property. (a method of communication, communicative practice)

Currie suggests that fictional properties, like non-fictional ones, have the semantic properties of truth value and reference. What this means is that a fictional statement can be true and false. For instance, consider the statement "Killing an NPC in monitored space will earn you a crime state". According to Currie, this statement is true. What makes something true

or false in a fiction, is its relation to the outside world. What is important however, is what this relationship is.

Readers and Authors

Because fiction is a relational property, they are community based and “depend on the prevailing attitudes of the community, or of a subgroup of the community rather than the ideas of a single individual” (Currie 1990, 10). For I take it that an act of joint authorship is exactly that: an act engaged in by more than one person rather than several distinct acts undertaken individually and patched together. (Currie 1990, 11)

The process of creating a fiction begins with the intention. It is not a singular intention however, but is a social enterprise. So maybe the reason that we do not call fake news, fiction, is because of the purposes and intent of fake news. It is intended to deceive rather than express true propositions. But if this is true, then why do we not consider that fiction is intended to deceive? Why does fiction have semantic properties such as truth whereas fake news does not? Currie (1990)

17.2 Pinero: Beasts as Symbols of Evil

The Manticore is a fictionalized beast that was born in Persian art and literature sometime around Persia’s cultural zenith. It at once symbolizes evil, death and hell, but in medieval religious art, it came to symbolize the power of Christ over death and hell.

It is an imagined beast that has been found in literature as early as the 5th and 4th century BC. In his Photius, the Greek historian working for the Persian court describes the Manticore as a beast with red skin, as large as a lion, possessing three rows of teeth, a human-like face and the tail of a scorpion. Later writers would quote Ctesias’ description of the Manticore adding emphasis on its dietary habits, including that it ate men. Though it is likely that many of these descriptions were of predatory animals passed by word of mouth until they reached the Persian king’s court, what is even more important is the way in which these descriptions begin to stand in for imageries of evil in the Medieval literature and specifically the kinds of evil they begin to represent.

On some accounts, the manticore is a union between a hyena and Ethiopian lioness. It imitates the voices of men and possesses a fixed and immovable gaze. In addition, it does not possess gums in either of its jaws, and rather than having multiple teeth, it has one large one that curves around its jaw bone.

Ctesias’ description includes that the Manticore had a triple row of teeth which fit into each other like a comb, the face and ears of a human, blood colored eyes, the body of a lion and a stinging tail similar to a scorpion. While Pliny the elder argued that it imitated the voices of men, Ctesias tells us that its voice resembles a union of a flute and trumpet, that it is exceedingly swift, and has an appetite for human flesh [p. 280].

Aristotle questions Ctesias' account, but nevertheless preserves it in his own writings. He also reproduces Ctesias' account, that the Manticore possesses a double rather than triple row of teeth, has similar feet as a lion and is similar in size to a lion. What is perhaps important are the anthropomorphic descriptions including those of the ears and face of a human, and that it has non-anthropomorphic ones such as grey eyes and red body and possesses a tail like that of a scorpion. [p. 30-31; also see Aristotle, *History of Animals* 8.28, 605b22-606a10]

Owing to the fantastical nature of these accounts, it is highly probable that they are either misguided representations of some more familiar animal, or motivated by purposes other than truth. In the classical era, it is most likely the case that the Manticore is a confused representation of some other more familiar animal, while in the medieval period, the motivation for the representation lies outside of truth.

On this second point, in the 57th question of the 1st of the second part of the *Summa Theologica*, Thomas Aquinas defends the view of art as a form of right reason. There is a distinction here between the right reason for making objects, and the right reason for doing good actions. We should first focus on a central point here, what is important to both of these activities, namely the right use of one's cognitive faculties. Therefore, the difference here lies in the produced object, whether an action or thing.

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